AN INTELLECTUAL & VISUAL HISTORY

How Brazil Became *Brazil*

Five centuries of geography, slavery, commodities, monarchy, migration and invention — told with Rio de Janeiro as a recurring protagonist.

Prologue · Five acts · Coda — about 50 minutes
Press → to advance, **N** for the deeper explanation behind any slide, **M** for sections.
Facts and contemporary data checked as of 24 October 2026.

Rafael Rabello de Barros, Rio de Janeiro from Corcovado: Botafogo, Sugarloaf and Gu..., 2011 · CC BY-SA 3.0 · Wikimedia Commons

Brazil is the great *anomaly* of the Americas

Four facts that do not fit the familiar story of the New World.
Explaining them is the best way into Brazil.

I *country*

Where Spanish America became eighteen

Spain's American empire broke into 18 Spanish-speaking republics. Portuguese America stayed whole — and today covers 47% of South America.

4.9m *Africans*

The heart of the Atlantic slave trade

About 4.9 million enslaved Africans arrived alive in Brazil — roughly 45% of everyone carried across the Atlantic, twelve times the number landed in what became the United States.

1808 *–1821*

An empire governed from its colony

Fleeing Napoleon, the Portuguese crown moved to Rio. For 13 years a South American port was the capital of a European empire. Independence came under a Portuguese prince — as a monarchy that lasted until 1889.

1888

The last to abolish slavery

Brazil was the final country in the Western Hemisphere to end slavery — 23 years after the United States, and with no land, compensation or schooling for the freed.

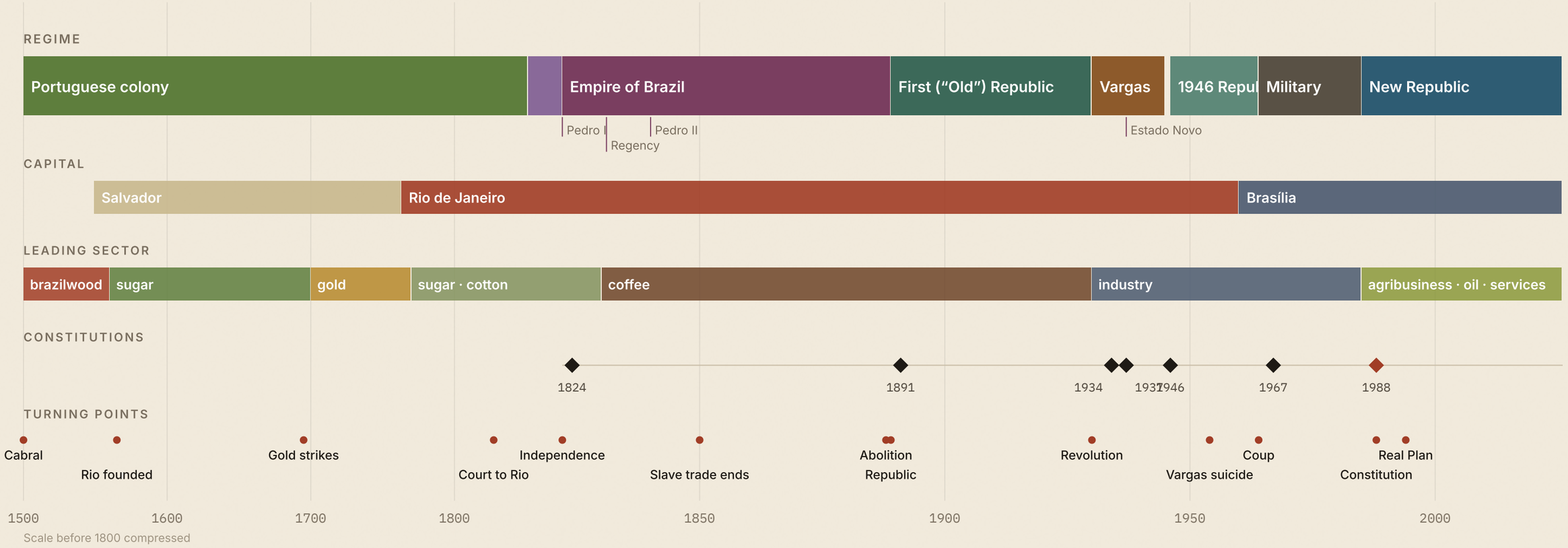
THE QUESTION

How did Brazil become the country it is — and why does Rio look, feel and function the way it does?

Sources: SlaveVoyages estimates 1501–1866 (4.86m disembarked in Brazil of 10.7m total); IBGE; Fausto & Fausto (2014).

Colony, kingdom, empire, republics, dictatorships, democracy — *on one line*

Seven constitutions and three capitals. Note how each regime change coincides with a shift in what Brazil sold to the world.

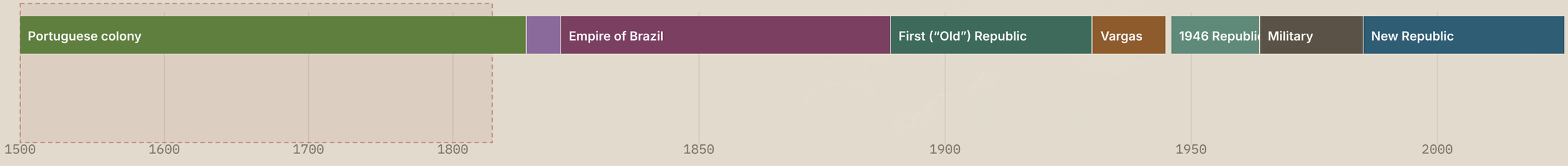


Act I

The Making of Colonial Brazil

c. 1500 – 1808

Why did a small European kingdom build a vast slave society in the tropics — and why did it keep pushing inland?



05 — GEOGRAPHY

A coast walled off from its interior — and rivers that ran *away* from the sea

1 The wall

Along the southeast, the Great Escarpment (Serra do Mar) rises 800–1,000 m within a few dozen kilometres of the shore. Good harbours behind it are rare — which is what made Guanabara Bay so valuable.

2 Rivers that point inland

Behind the wall, the Tietê flows west, away from São Paulo's coast, into the Paraná basin. It turned São Paulo into a launch pad for expeditions into the continent rather than a port.

3 Two Brazils by sea

Winds and currents made the north coast (Maranhão, Pará) easier to reach from Lisbon than from Salvador. Until the 1770s it was governed as a separate colony.

Shaded relief from AWS Terrain Tiles (SRTM/GMTED/ETOPO1); rivers: Natural Earth; escarpment and Tietê course drawn approximately.

Albert Eckhout, Tupi man, 1643 · National Museum of Denmark · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Albert Eckhout, Tupi woman, 1641 · National Museum of Denmark · CC BY-SA 3.0 · Wikimedia Commons

06 — BEFORE 1500

Millions of people, not an empty forest

Portuguese ships met coastal Tupi-speaking peoples who had themselves recently expanded along the shore. Within a century, epidemics, war and enslavement had emptied much of the coast.

2–4m+

Plausible range for the population of what is now Brazil in 1500. Estimates are genuinely uncertain; Amazon floodplains were far more densely settled than once assumed.

1563

Smallpox and famine sweep the Jesuit villages of Bahia, killing tens of thousands — one reason planters turned to Africa for labour.

1.69m

Indigenous people counted in the 2022 census (0.8% of Brazil) — hundreds of peoples speaking well over 200 languages.

YOU WILL HEAR TUPI ALL OVER RIO

Guanabara — the bay

Carioca — a native of Rio (likely "white man's house")

Tijuca — "marsh, mud"

Ipanema — "bad / barren water"

Niterói — "hidden water"

Maracanã — a kind of macaw

Etymologies are traditional and some are disputed. **Copacabana** is the exception: the name comes from an Andean shrine to the Virgin of Copacabana on Lake Titicaca.

Paintings: Albert Eckhout, "Tupi man" and "Tupi woman", 1641–43, painted in Dutch Brazil (National Museum of Denmark). Census: IBGE 2022.

07 — PORTUGAL'S ATLANTIC

A small kingdom found Brazil *on the way to India*

Portugal had perhaps 1–1.5 million people. Its fortune lay in Asian spices, and Brazil was a by-product: Cabral's India fleet swung far west to catch the South Atlantic winds and struck the coast in April 1500.

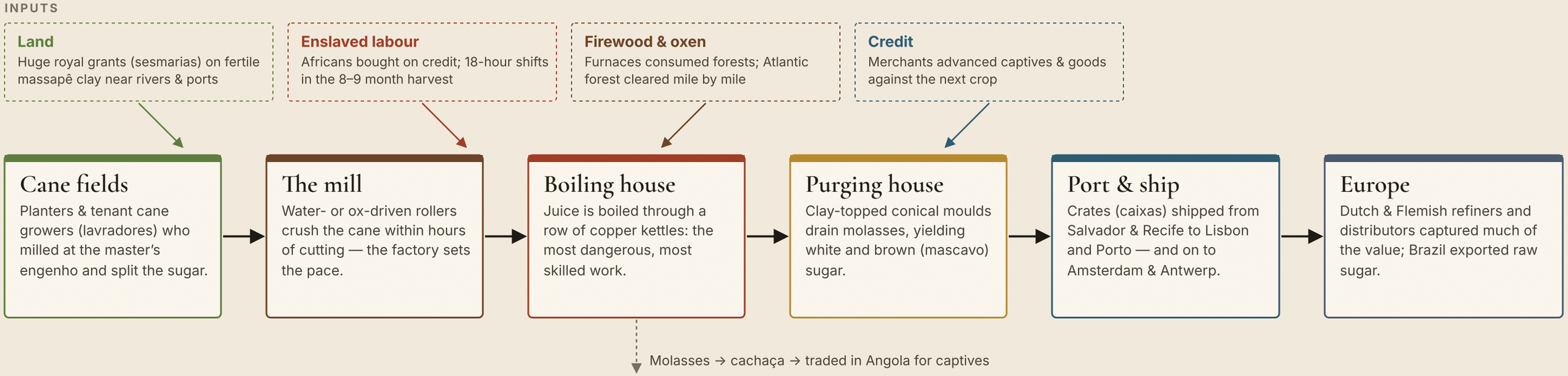
For thirty years the only business was **brazilwood**, a red dye-wood (brasa = ember) that gave the land its name. Only French interlopers forced the Crown to settle — first by handing coastal strips to private "donatários" (1534), then by founding a royal capital at Salvador (1549).

The template already existed on the Atlantic islands: **Madeira** proved sugar; **São Tomé** proved sugar worked by enslaved Africans.

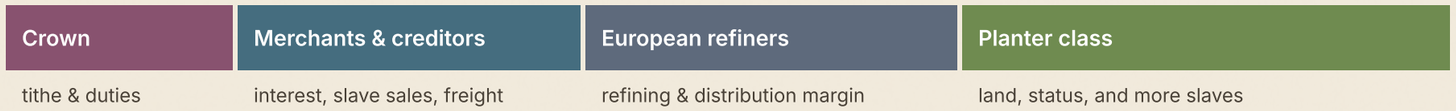
The Cantino planisphere, 1502 — smuggled from Lisbon to Italy. It already shows the Tordesillas line and a Brazilian coast decorated with parrots and trees.

Map: author's reconstruction on shaded relief. Cantino map: Biblioteca Estense, Modena (public domain).

Sugar made Brazil a business — and the business ran on *enslaved Africans*



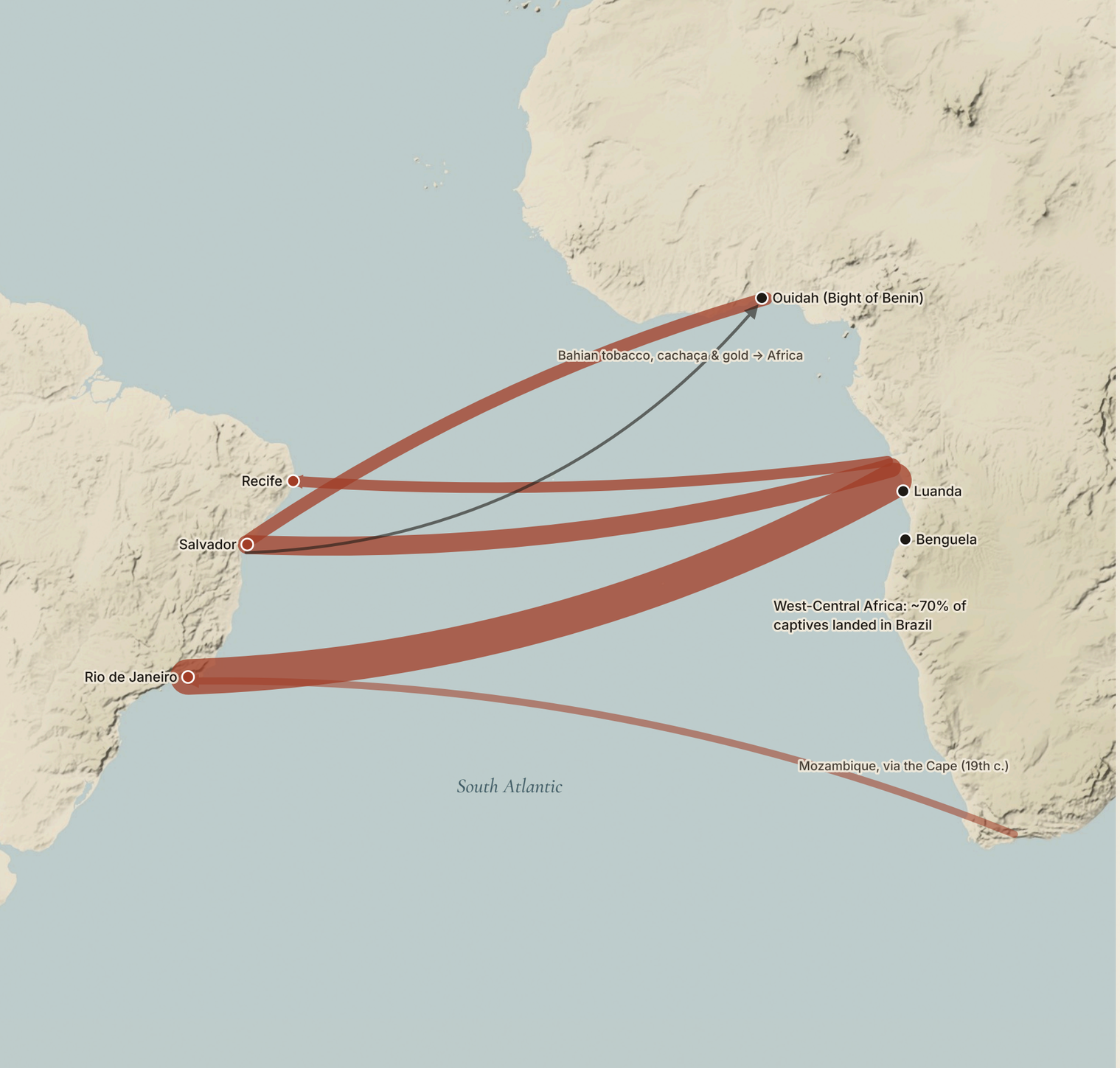
WHERE THE SURPLUS WENT



Shares are schematic, not measured — they show who had claims on the crop, not exact proportions.

> *"The slaves are the hands and the feet of the sugar-mill owner."*
>
> André João Antonil (the Jesuit Giovanni Antonio Andreoni), *Cultura e Opulência do Brasil*, 1711 — a planter's manual the Crown suppressed for revealing too much about colonial wealth.

By around 1600 Brazil was the world's largest sugar producer. The engenho was a **factory in a field**: capital-intensive, time-critical and dependent on a labour force that could be driven without limit. Status followed: "to be a senhor de engenho," wrote Antonil, "is a title to which many aspire."

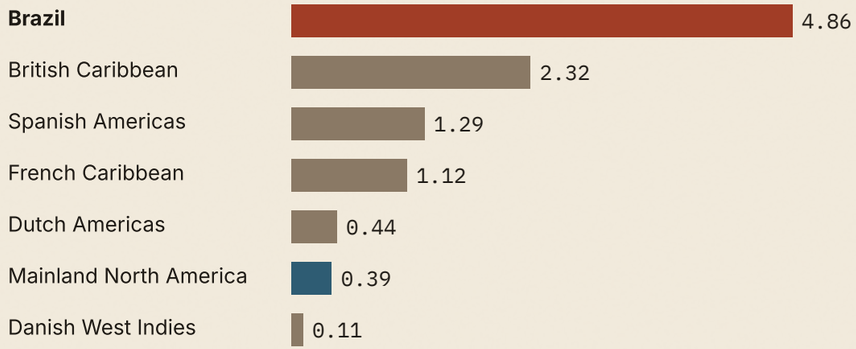


09 — THE SOUTH ATLANTIC SYSTEM

Brazil was built from the *South Atlantic*, not just from Europe

Winds and currents made Angola and Brazil a natural circuit. Ships owned in Rio and Salvador sailed direct to Africa with cachaça, tobacco and gold, and returned with captives — a bilateral trade that often bypassed Lisbon entirely.

ENSLAVED AFRICANS LANDED ALIVE, 1501–1866 (MILLIONS)



WITHIN BRAZIL

About 12.5 million people were embarked in Africa; some 1.8 million died at sea. In 1648 an expedition *from Rio* retook Luanda from the Dutch — Rio's merchants needed Angola.

Data: SlaveVoyages, Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database estimates (rounded). Flow widths are schematic.

Brazil received twelve times more Africans than the United States — and ended with *fewer* enslaved people

Two mechanisms explain the paradox, and together they shaped modern Brazil's racial order:

1. Death outpaced birth. Plantations and port cities killed enslaved people faster than they could reproduce; the captives imported were mostly young men. While the trade was open, owners replenished by purchase. The US enslaved population, by contrast, grew by natural increase after its trade ended in 1808.

2. Manumission was common. Many enslaved Brazilians — especially women and city dwellers — bought or were granted freedom. By 1872 free people of African descent outnumbered both the enslaved and the white population.

The result was not a two-caste society but a **graded colour hierarchy**, with a large free population of colour — and slavery nonetheless intact.

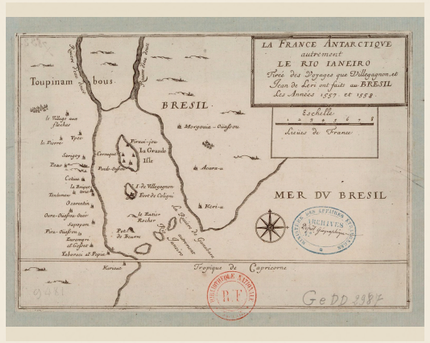
Brazil 1872 also counted 0.39m "caboclos" (of Indigenous descent). Total population 9.93m.

Sources: SlaveVoyages estimates (arrivals); US Census 1860; Recenseamento Geral do Império, 1872 (IBGE). Free Black & pardo = pretos + pardos counted minus enslaved.

Rio was founded to keep the French out — on a bay built for defence

Guanabara is a vast, sheltered, deep-water bay behind a narrow entrance — rare on a coast walled by mountains. In 1555 the French got there first: Nicolas de Villegaignon founded **“France Antarctique”** on an island in the bay, allied with the Tamoio peoples.

The Portuguese answered with Jesuit diplomacy, Indigenous allies and force. Estácio de Sá founded São Sebastião do Rio de Janeiro on **1 March 1565** at the foot of Sugarloaf; after his death from an arrow wound, the city was moved to a defensible hilltop — Morro do Castelo — in 1567.



“La France Antarctique, autrement le Rio Ianeiro” — a French map after the voyages of Villegaignon and Jean de Léry (1557–58). The name means “River of January”: the bay was reportedly taken for a river mouth on 1 January 1502.

Map: shaded relief (AWS Terrain Tiles) with IBGE coastline; site positions approximate.

Gold dragged Brazil south and inland — and made Rio the capital

São Paulo’s slave-raiding expeditions found gold in the 1690s in what became Minas Gerais. The result was the largest gold rush the world had yet seen: hundreds of thousands of Portuguese migrants and enslaved Africans poured inland.

The fastest route to the sea ran to **Rio**. The Caminho Novo turned a modest port into the colony’s main outlet for gold and its main market for slaves, and in **1763** the capital moved from Salvador to Rio.

Colonial Brazil’s population grew roughly tenfold over the century, to about 3 million.

Raquel Mendes Silva, Ouro Preto, historic centre, 2014 · CC BY-SA 4.0 · Wikimedia Commons

Ouro Preto (Vila Rica): baroque churches built on gold. Routes drawn approximately after FGV Atlas Histórico.

The centre of gravity kept moving — *and Brazil followed it*

2020s

Brasília, soy, and offshore oil

A planned inland capital (1960), an agribusiness frontier across the Cerrado, and deep-water “pre-salt” oil off Rio and São Paulo. But people and money remain concentrated in the southeast.

CAPITAL
Brasília

SCALE
Population 203 million (2022 census)

Press → to step through six moments. Dashed outline: today’s borders, for orientation. Zones are schematic.

Nicolas-Antoine Taunay, View of Glória beach and church, Rio, 1816–17 · Museu Nacional de Belas Artes · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Act II

An Empire in the Tropics

1808 – 1889

Why did Brazil become an independent monarchy rather than a republic — and why did it hold on to slavery longer than anyone else?

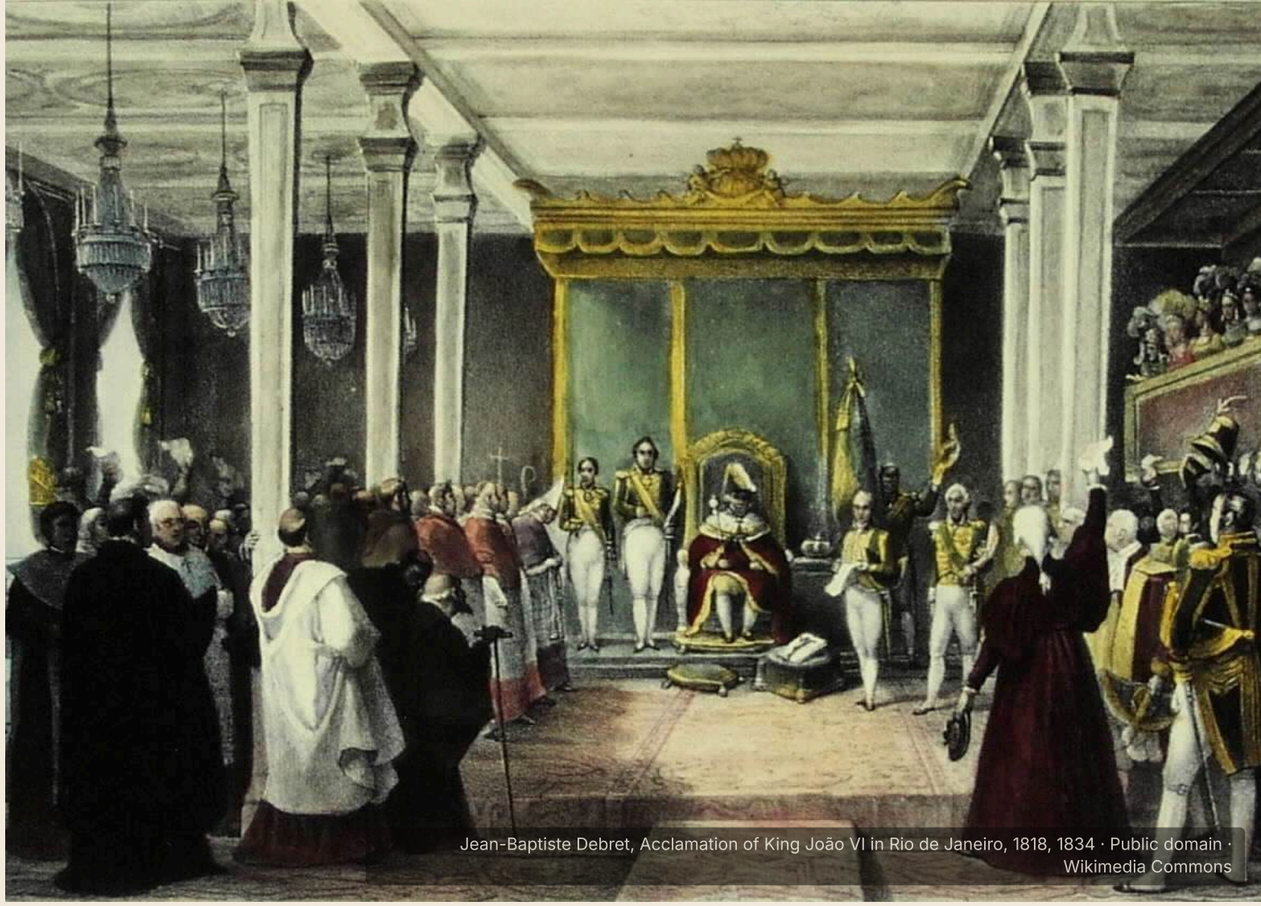
A European empire came to be governed *from its colony*

In November 1807, as Napoleon’s army closed on Lisbon, the Prince Regent João sailed for Brazil under British naval escort with the royal family, the government and thousands of courtiers. In March 1808 they landed in Rio.

A colonial port became an imperial capital almost overnight. Its population roughly doubled in about a decade; the colony’s ports were opened to foreign — above all British — trade, ending three centuries of Portuguese monopoly.

CREATED IN RIO BY THE COURT — MOST STILL EXIST

- 1808 Banco do Brasil
- 1808 Botanical Garden
- 1810 Military Academy
- 1808 Royal Press & first newspaper
- 1810 Royal Library (now Biblioteca Nacional)
- 1816 French Artistic Mission → Academy of Fine Arts



Jean-Baptiste Debret, Acclamation of King João VI in Rio de Janeiro, 1818, 1834 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Debret, the acclamation of João VI, Rio, 6 February 1818 — staged at the Paço on what is now Praça XV, the only time a reigning European monarch was acclaimed in the Americas.

1815
Brazil raised to a kingdom co-equal with Portugal

1820
Liberals in Porto, furious at being “a colony of a colony,” demand the king’s return

Dates: Wilcken (2004); Schultz (2001). Court size is contested — see notes.

Pedro Américo, Independência ou Morte! (The Cry of Ipiranga), 1888 · Museu Paulista, USP · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Pedro Américo, *Independência ou Morte!* (1888) — painted 66 years after the event as national myth. Witnesses suggest the prince, suffering from an upset stomach, was riding a mule.

16 — 1821–1825

Independence came as a *dynastic split*, not a revolution

When Lisbon's new parliament tried to reverse Rio's status, Brazil's elites rallied around the heir who had stayed behind. On 7 September 1822 Pedro declared independence near São Paulo; in December he was crowned Emperor in Rio. Portugal recognised it in 1825 — after Britain brokered a deal in which Brazil took over £2 million of Portuguese debt.

It was not bloodless — there was real fighting in Bahia, Maranhão and Pará — but the state, the dynasty and the social order survived intact.

WHY THE TWO EMPIRES ENDED SO DIFFERENTLY

Spanish America

1808: Napoleon captures the Spanish king. Legitimacy collapses; local juntas, civil wars (1810–25). Four viceroyalties and many audiencias become 18 republics.

Portuguese America

1808: the king escapes to Rio with the state. One court, one treasury, one army — and an heir in place to claim the whole territory as a single empire.

Slaveholding elites also wanted continuity: a monarchy promised order at a time when Haiti's revolution (1791–1804) haunted every plantation society.

Barman (1988); Carvalho, A Construção da Ordem; Fausto & Fausto (2014).

Unity was not destiny: the Empire had to *hold* Brazil together

After Pedro I abdicated in 1831, leaving a five-year-old heir, a decade of regency nearly broke the country apart. Uruguay did break away. Historians weigh several explanations for why the rest held:

An elite of one mould

Coimbra-trained magistrates and bureaucrats rotated across provinces, forming a national ruling class.

Fear as glue

Provincial slaveholders needed a strong central army against slave revolt — as Salvador's Malê uprising (1835) showed.

A crown worth joining

Rio's court distributed titles, offices and credit; the 1840 coronation of the 14-year-old Pedro II restored a symbol of unity.

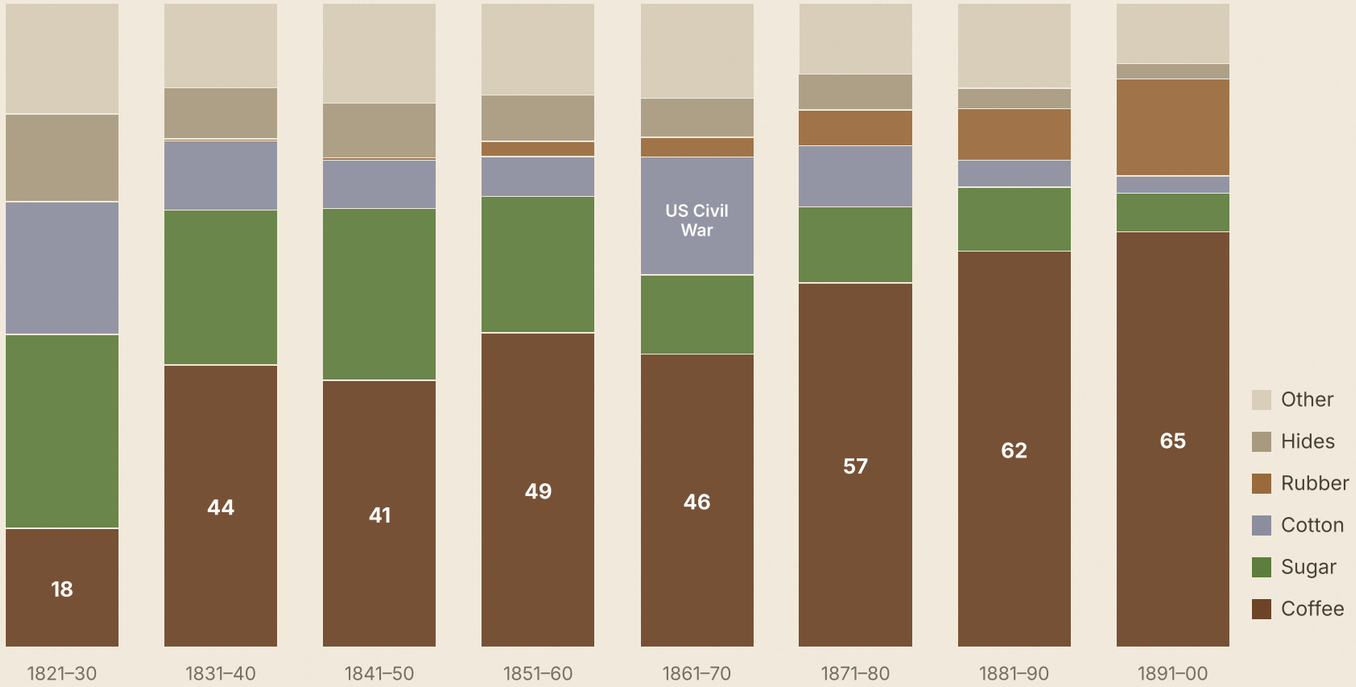
Force

The army and National Guard, under commanders like Caxias, crushed revolts one by one.

Carvalho, A Construção da Ordem; Barman (1988). Locations approximate.

Coffee rebuilt the economy around Rio — on the last great wave of the slave trade

SHARE OF BRAZIL'S EXPORT EARNINGS BY DECADE (%)



Marc Ferrez, Enslaved workers on a coffee fazenda, Paraíba valley, c. 1885 · Instituto Moreira Salles · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Marc Ferrez, c. 1885: enslaved workers on a coffee fazenda in the Paraíba valley, three years before abolition.

Coffee climbed from the hills of Rio up the **Paraíba valley** from the 1820s. It was planted by enslaved Africans: roughly **2 million** captives landed in Brazil in 1801–1850, more than in any earlier half-century — most of them through Rio, and much of it illegally after a ban of 1831 that was passed, as the phrase went, *"para inglês ver"* — for the English to see.

Export shares: IBGE, Estatísticas Históricas do Brasil (from Anuário Estatístico 1939/40), as reproduced in Fausto & Fausto. Arrivals: SlaveVoyages estimates.

Johann Moritz Rugendas, Slave market (Marché aux nègres), Rio de Janeiro, c. 1835 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Halley Pacheco de Oliveira, Valongo and Empress wharfs, archaeological site, 2012 · CC BY-SA 3.0 · Wikimedia Commons

Pedra do Sal

Felipe Restrepo Acosta, Pedra do Sal, 2018 · CC BY-SA 4.0 · Wikimedia Commons

19 — RIO · VALONGO, 1770S–1831

The largest slave port in the Americas — buried, and rediscovered

In the 1770s the viceroy moved Rio's slave market from the centre to **Valongo**, a cove just beyond the city, to keep the sick and dying newly arrived out of sight. A wharf was built in 1811. UNESCO estimates that some **900,000** enslaved Africans were landed through the Valongo complex — warehouses, a quarantine house, and a cemetery for those who died on arrival.

In 1843 the wharf was paved over for the arrival of an empress; in the 1900s it vanished under landfill. Excavations for the 2016 Olympics found it again in 2011. It became a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2017.

41%

of Rio's 266,466 people were enslaved in the 1849 census — the largest urban slave population in the Americas

WHEN YOU GO

Valongo Wharf → Instituto Pretos Novos (the cemetery, on Rua Pedro Ernesto) → Pedra do Sal (right): a 15-minute walk through "Little Africa."

Top: Rugendas, *Marché aux nègres* (Rua do Valongo), 1835. UNESCO WHC 1548; 1849 census (Karasch 1987).

Slavery was not so much abolished as *slowly strangled* — and the freed received nothing

1831	Trade banned — and ignored
1850	Atlantic trade ends (British pressure)
1850	Land Law: land only by purchase
1871	Free Womb Law
1880s	Abolitionist movement; mass flights
1884	Ceará and Amazonas abolish
1885	Sexagenarian Law
13 May 1888	Lei Áurea: unconditional abolition

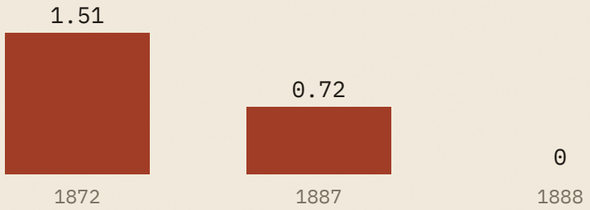
THE ENTIRE GOLDEN LAW

Art. 1. Slavery in Brazil is declared extinct from the date of this law.
Art. 2. All provisions to the contrary are revoked.

Antônio Luiz Ferreira, Crowd at the Paço Imperial on 13 May 1888, 1888 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

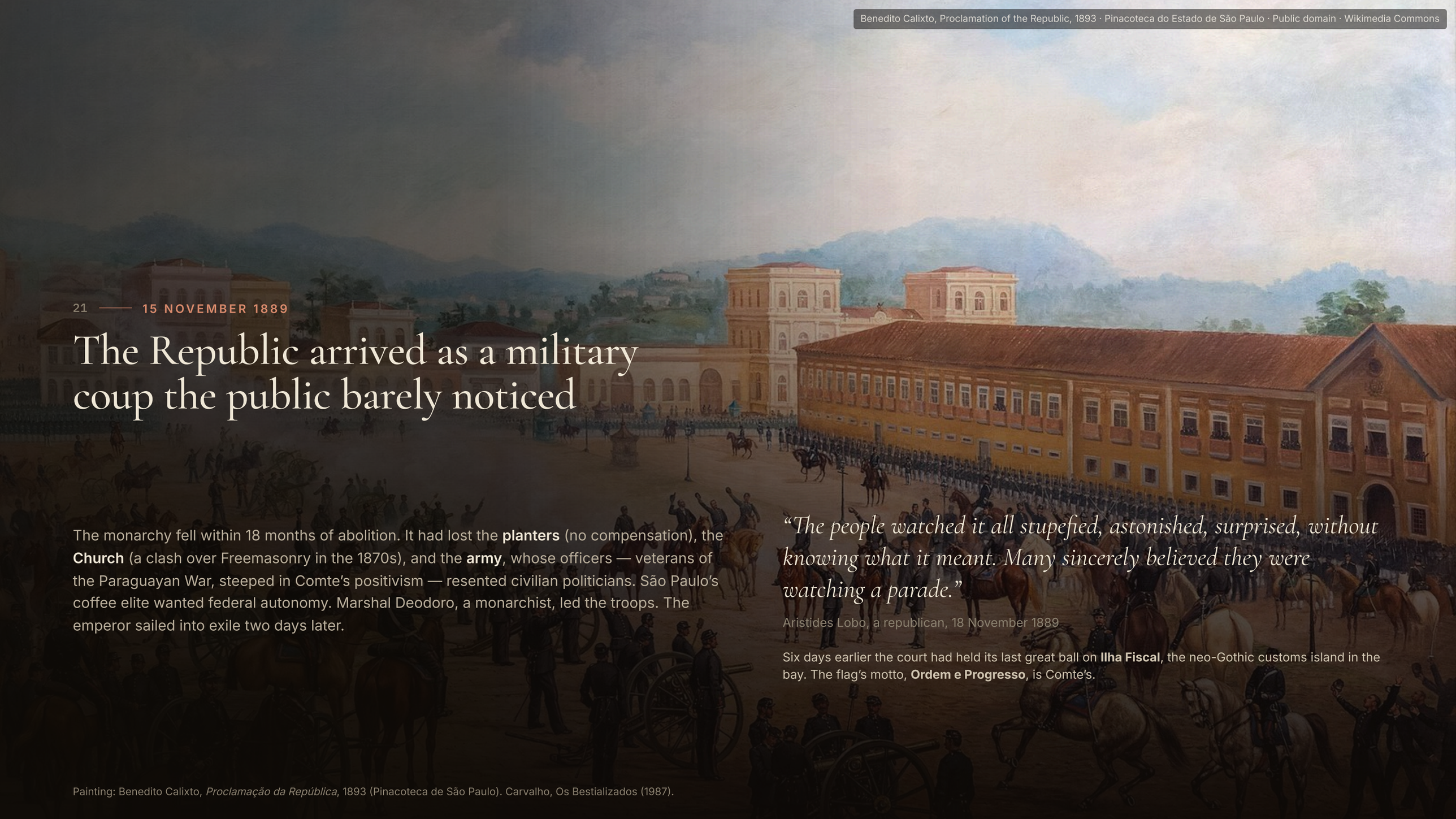
13 May 1888, Paço Imperial (Praça XV): crowds outside the palace as Princess Isabel signs the law, in Pedro II's absence abroad.

ENSLAVED POPULATION (MILLIONS)



No compensation to owners — and none to the freed: no land, no schooling, no wages guaranteed. Many planters turned republican overnight.

Census 1872; 1887 slave registry (matrícula). Conrad (1972); Machado (1994).



Benedito Calixto, Proclamation of the Republic, 1893 · Pinacoteca do Estado de São Paulo · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

21 — 15 NOVEMBER 1889

The Republic arrived as a military coup the public barely noticed

The monarchy fell within 18 months of abolition. It had lost the **planters** (no compensation), the **Church** (a clash over Freemasonry in the 1870s), and the **army**, whose officers — veterans of the Paraguayan War, steeped in Comte's positivism — resented civilian politicians. São Paulo's coffee elite wanted federal autonomy. Marshal Deodoro, a monarchist, led the troops. The emperor sailed into exile two days later.

"The people watched it all stupefied, astonished, surprised, without knowing what it meant. Many sincerely believed they were watching a parade."

Aristides Lobo, a republican, 18 November 1889

Six days earlier the court had held its last great ball on **Ilha Fiscal**, the neo-Gothic customs island in the bay. The flag's motto, **Ordem e Progresso**, is Comte's.

Painting: Benedito Calixto, *Proclamação da República*, 1893 (Pinacoteca de São Paulo). Carvalho, Os Bestializados (1987).

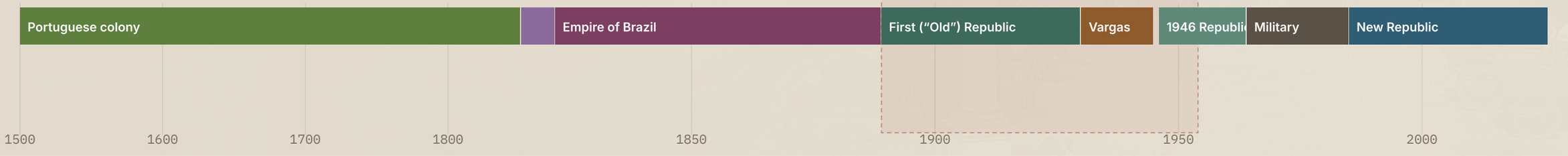
Marc Ferrez, Avenida Central (now Rio Branco), c. 1906 · Instituto Moreira Salles · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Act III

The Creation of Modern Brazil

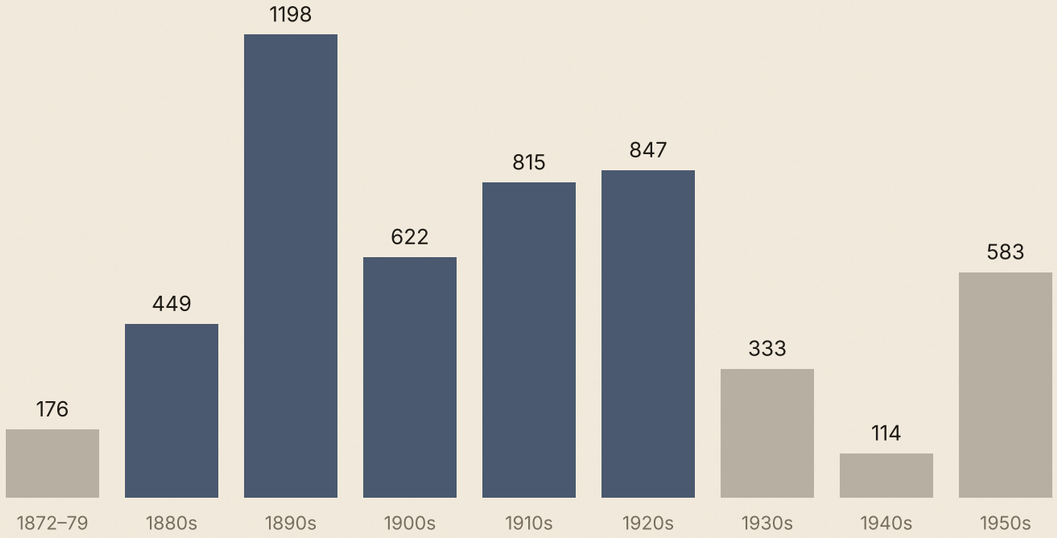
1889 – 1954

How did a coffee republic run by a few thousand voters become an urban, industrial, mass society — and who was let in?



A federation of coffee oligarchs chose European immigrants over Brazil's own freed people

IMMIGRANTS ARRIVING IN BRAZIL, BY DECADE (THOUSANDS)



Mostly Italians, Portuguese and Spaniards; Japanese from 1908. São Paulo paid many passages.

"To Brazil! Free passage" — 1886 poster recruiting Italian families for São Paulo's coffee farms, where they replaced enslaved labour under the *colonato* system.

An 1890 decree opened Brazil to immigrants — except "natives of Asia and Africa," who needed Congress's approval. Elites spoke openly of **"whitening"** the nation.

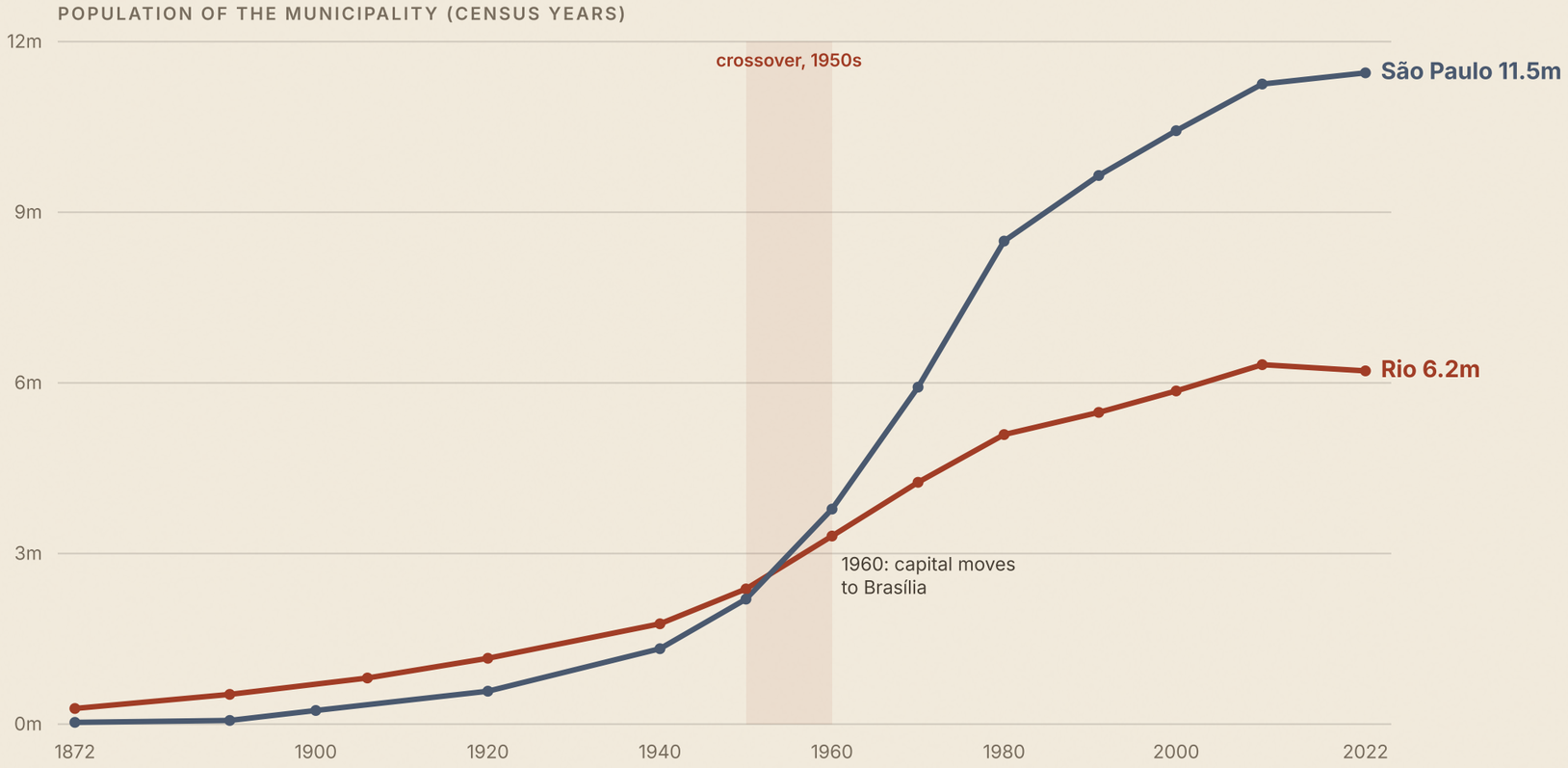
Politics was a pact of state oligarchies — São Paulo and Minas above all — resting on local bosses (*coronéis*) who delivered votes. Before 1930 no presidential election drew votes from more than about 6% of the population.

Canudos, 1896–97

The army destroyed a religious community of backlanders in Bahia led by Antônio Conselheiro — estimates run up to 25,000 people — killing most of its defenders. Returning soldiers settled on a Rio hillside they nicknamed **Morro da Favella** — see slide 25.

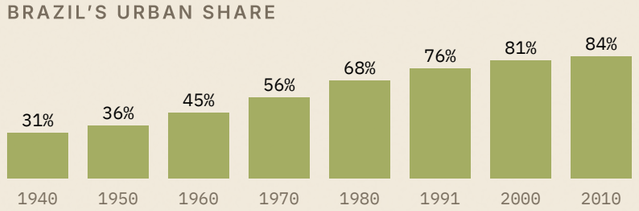
Immigration: IBGE / Levy (1974), entries by decade. Holloway (1980); Skidmore, Black into White (1974); Leal (1949).

Rio stayed the capital — but coffee money made *São Paulo* the engine



In 1872 São Paulo was a provincial town of 31,000. Its rise came from the coffee frontier to its west and three advantages Rio lacked: a **British railway** down the escarpment to Santos (1867), **immigrant wage-earners** who formed a consumer market, and planters who reinvested in **industry** and hydroelectric power.

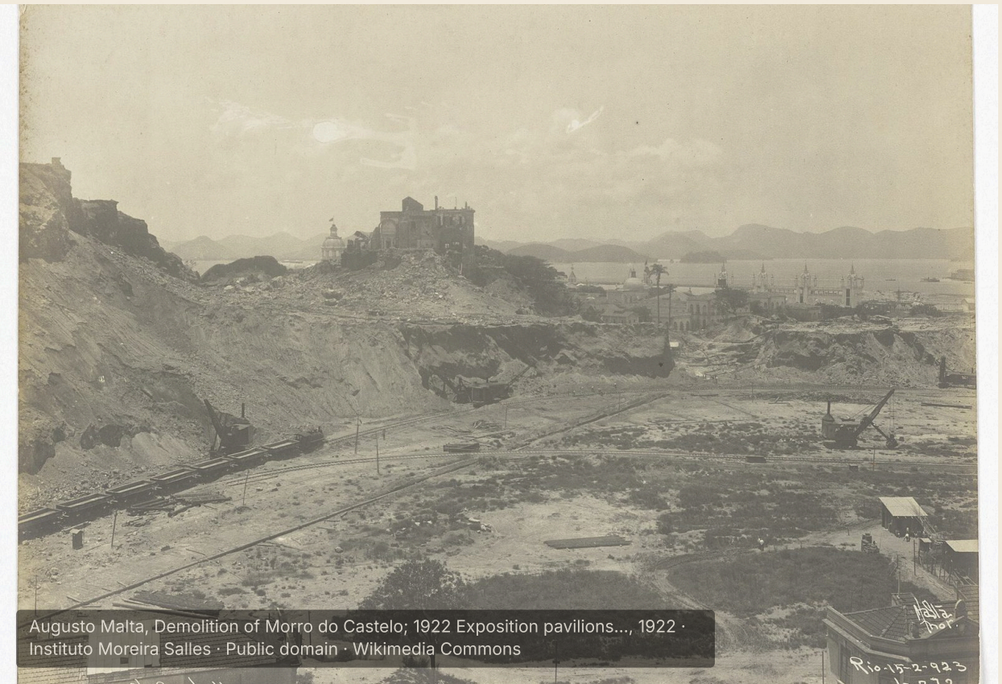
Rio kept politics, the navy, finance, the press and culture — until 1960.



IBGE censuses 1872–2022 (Rio: Município Neutro / Distrito Federal / Guanabara / município; 1906 Rio census). Urban share: IBGE.

Rio was rebuilt to look like Paris — and its poor were pushed *up the hills*

Marc Ferrez, Theatro Municipal, c. 1909 · Instituto Moreira Salles · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons



Augusto Malta, Demolition of Morro do Castelo; 1922 Exposition pavilions..., 1922 · Instituto Moreira Salles · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Around 1900 Rio was notorious for yellow fever and smallpox; foreign ships avoided it. President Rodrigues Alves gave the engineer-mayor **Pereira Passos** and the sanitarian **Oswaldo Cruz** a free hand. The "bota-abaixo" (knock-it-down) demolished hundreds of tenements to drive the Avenida Central through the colonial core and rebuild the port.

In 1904 compulsory smallpox vaccination set off the **Revolta da Vacina**: a week of barricades in Saúde and the port, about 30 dead, hundreds deported to Acre.

Evicted workers moved to the suburbs — or to the hills near their jobs. In 1920–22 the city went further and **razed Morro do Castelo**, its founding hill (left).

"Guerra Vaccino-Obrigateza!" — Oswaldo Cruz as a lancer of vaccine, satirical cartoon, 1904.

Why "favela"?

Canudos veterans, awaiting pay in 1897, camped on Morro da Providência and named it after the favela shrub of the Bahian hills. Hillside shacks existed earlier; the name stuck to them all.

Left: Theatro Municipal (1909), Marc Ferrez; demolition of Morro do Castelo, 1922, Augusto Malta. Benchimol (1990); Sevcenko (1984); Valladares (2005).

The city grew in three directions — each with its own *class logic*

1960–today

Capital lost; the city sprawls west

Brasília takes the capital. Landfill creates the Aterro; the Rebouças tunnel (1967) links north and south. Favela removals build Cidade de Deus. Barra da Tijuca grows as a car-based new city; militias dominate much of the west.

SEE IT TODAY

Aterro do Flamengo, Barra, Olympic Park, Porto Maravilha

Image: Rio at night from the ISS, 2022 (NASA)

Baixada Fluminense →

Guanabara Bay

ZONA NORTE

Central railway, 1858

Madureira

São Cristóvão

Centro

Niterói

Tijuca

ZONA OESTE

Aterro (landfill)

Rebouças tunnel, 1967

TIJUCA MASSIF

Botafogo

ZONA SUL

tunnels 1892 · 1906

Lagoa

Copacabana

Ipanema · Leblon

Barra da Tijuca

Atlantic Ocean

Zones schematic, after Abreu, Evolução Urbana do Rio de Janeiro. Relief: AWS Terrain Tiles; coastline: IBGE. → steps through eras.

Government of Brazil, Getúlio Vargas, c. 1930 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Vargas built the modern Brazilian state — and much of it still runs on his blueprint

The 1929 crash shattered the coffee republic. Getúlio Vargas, a gaúcho politician, took power in the **Revolution of 1930**; in 1937 he closed Congress and ruled as dictator of the **Estado Novo** until 1945, with censorship, a political police and propaganda. Elected again in 1950, he shot himself in the Catete Palace in 1954 rather than be deposed.

His bargain: **urban formal workers** received rights, minimum wages and state-supervised unions; rural and domestic workers were left out. The divide between the protected formal sector and the informal majority dates from here.

INSTITUTIONS OF THE VARGAS YEARS — ALL STILL EXIST

1930	Ministry of Labour, Industry & Commerce
1932	Secret ballot; votes for women; the work card (carteira)
1936	IBGE, the statistics bureau
1940	National minimum wage
1941	CSN steelworks at Volta Redonda (with US credit)
1942	Vale do Rio Doce (now Vale)
1943	CLT — the Consolidated Labour Laws
1952–53	BNDE development bank; Petrobras (“O petróleo é nosso”)

“I leave life to enter history.”

Vargas’s farewell letter, 24 August 1954. His bedroom in the Catete Palace — now the Museu da República in Flamengo — is preserved as it was.

French, Drowning in Laws (2004); Williams (2001); Abreu (ed.), A Ordem do Progresso (2014); CPDOC.

Samba began as a *policed* Afro-Brazilian practice — and became the nation's sound

Tia Ciata

Donga

Pixinguinha

Heitor dos Prazeres

Cartola

Bahian migrants in "Little Africa" — around Pedra do Sal and Praça Onze — hosted the gatherings where samba took shape; the house of the Candomblé priestess **Tia Ciata** was the most famous. *Pelo Telefone*, registered by Donga in 1916, became the first hit recorded as "samba."

In 1928 sambistas of Estácio founded **Deixa Falar**, the first "samba school"; parades began in 1932 and the city made them official in 1935. Radio, records and the Vargas state turned a music once associated with vagrancy into the national rhythm.

Where: Pedra do Sal (Monday nights) · Madureira — Portela & Império Serrano · Mangueira · the Sambódromo (1984), near the vanished Praça Onze.

Right: Portela at the Sambódromo, 2014 (Agência Brasil). Vianna (1995); Sandroni (2001); McCann (2004).

Fernando Frazão / Agência Brasil, Portela samba school parade, Sambódromo, 2014 · CC BY 3.0 br · Wikimedia Commons

“Racial democracy” was a powerful national myth — the data have never matched it

In 1933 Gilberto Freyre’s *Casa-Grande & Senzala* turned the old elite fear of race-mixing upside down: miscegenation was Brazil’s genius. In the 1930s–50s football and samba seemed to prove it, and “racial democracy” became official self-image.

Researchers sent by UNESCO in the 1950s expecting harmony found pervasive discrimination; from the 1970s statisticians showed that colour, not just class, shapes life chances. Since 2012 federal universities reserve places for Black, pardo and Indigenous students.

HOW BRAZILIANS IDENTIFY, 2022 CENSUS

Pardo (mixed) **45.3%** White **43.5%** Black (preto) **10.2%** Indigenous **0.6%**

Asian-descent **0.4%**

Black and pardo Brazilians — 55% of the population — earn on average roughly 40% less than white Brazilians and account for around three-quarters of homicide victims.

Rio de Janeiro, 7 de Abril de 1924.

Officio No 261

Exmo. Snr. Dr. Arnaldo Guinle,

M. D. Presidente da Associação Metropolitana de Esportes Athleticos.

As resoluções divulgadas hoje pela Imprensa, tomadas em reunião de hontem pelos altos poderes da Associação a que V. Exa. tão dignamente preside, collocam o Club de Regatas Vasco da Gama numa tal situação de inferioridade, que absolutamente não pode ser justificada, nem pelas deficiencias do nosso campo, nem pela simplicidade da nossa séde, nem pela condição modesta de grande numero dos nossos associados.

Os previlegios concedidos aos cinco clubs fundadores da A.M.E.A., e a forma porque será exercido o direito de discussão a voto, e feitas as futuras classificações, obrigam-nos a lavrar o nosso protesto contra as citadas resoluções.

Quanto á condição de eliminarmos doze dos nossos jogadores das nossas equipes, resolveu por unanimidade a Directoria do C.R. Vasco da Gama não a dever acceitar, por não se conformar com o processo porque foi feita a investigação das posições sociaes desses nossos consocios, investigação levada a um tribunal onde não tiveram nem representação nem defesa.

Estamos certos que V. Exa. será o primeiro a reconhecer que seria um acto pouco digno da nossa parte, sacrificar ao desejo de fazer parte da A.M.E.A., alguns dos que luctaram para que tivessemos entre outras victorias, a do Campeonato de Foot-Ball da Cidade do Rio de Janeiro de 1923.

São esses doze jogadores, jovens, quasi todos brasileiros, no começo de sua carreira, e o acto publico que os pode macular, nunca será praticado com a solidariedade dos que dirigem a casa que os acolheu, nem sob o pavilhão que elles com tanta galhardia cobriram de glorias.

Nestes termos, sentimos ter que comunicar a V. Exa. que desistimos de fazer parte da A.M.E.A.

Queira V. Exa. acceitar os protestos da maior consideração estima de quem tem a honra de subscrever

De V. Exa. Atto Vnr., Obrigado.

(a) José Augusto Prestes
Presidente

CLUB DE REGATAS VASCO DA GAMA
CENTRO DE MEMÓRIA

Football’s colour line

Early clubs like Fluminense (1902) were elite and white. In 1923 **Vasco da Gama**, a club of Portuguese shopkeepers, won Rio’s league with Black and working-class players. Told to drop twelve of them to join the new elite league, Vasco refused in the **“Resposta Histórica”** of 7 April 1924 (left).

Professionalism (1933) opened the game. Yet when Brazil lost the 1950 World Cup final to Uruguay before some 200,000 at the Maracanã, the blame fell disproportionately on Black players, especially the goalkeeper Barbosa.

IBGE Censo 2022 (identificação étnico-racial); IBGE, Desigualdades Sociais por Cor ou Raça; Atlas da Violência (IPEA/FBSP). Freyre (1933); Fernandes (1964); Hasenbalg (1979); Mário Filho (1947).

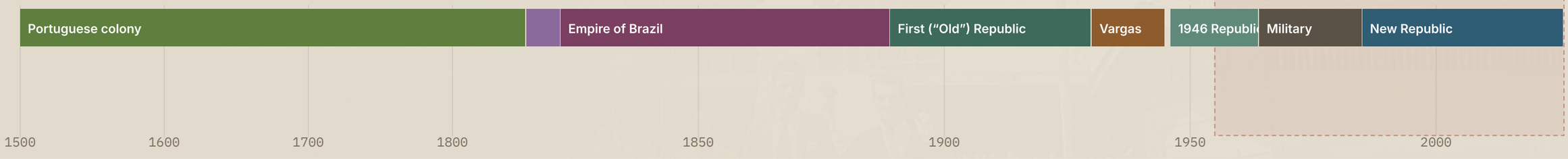
Unknown photographer, Building the National Congress, Esplanada dos Ministérios, 1959 · Arquivo Público do DF · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

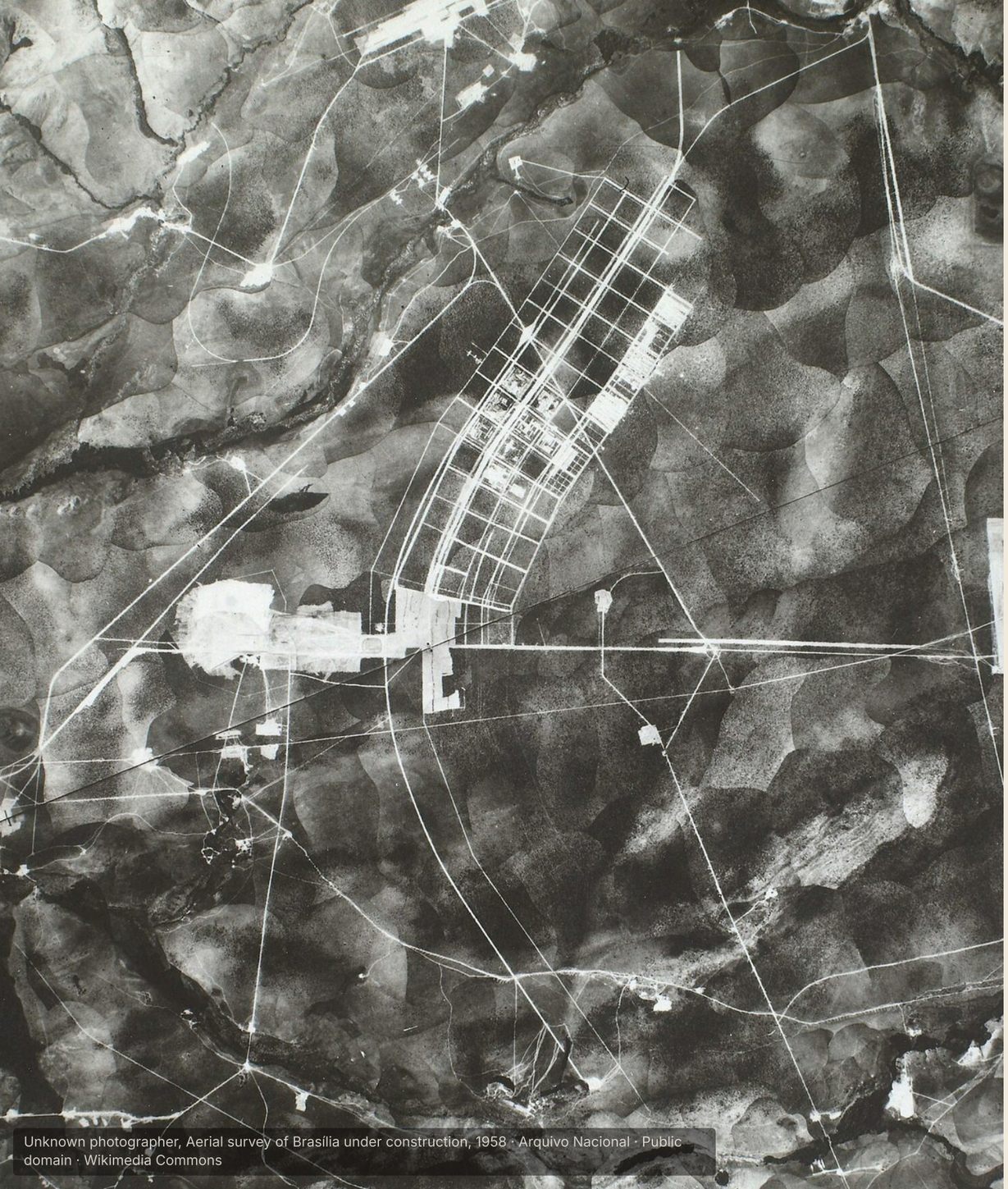
Act IV

Dictatorship, Democracy & Economic Transformation

1955 – 2026

Why has Brazil swung so often between developmental promise and crisis — and between authoritarian and democratic rule?





Unknown photographer, Aerial survey of Brasília under construction, 1958 · Arquivo Nacional · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

A capital built in 41 months to pull Brazil inland — and away from Rio

The 1891 constitution had already reserved land on the central plateau for a new capital. President **Juscelino Kubitschek** (1956–61), promising "fifty years of progress in five," built it: Lúcio Costa's airplane-shaped plan, Oscar Niemeyer's buildings, inaugurated on **21 April 1960**.

Highways radiated to Belém and the west; the car industry arrived around São Paulo. The bill came as inflation and foreign debt.

The planned city never housed its builders: migrant workers (*candangos*) settled in satellite towns that now hold most of the Federal District's 2.8 million people.

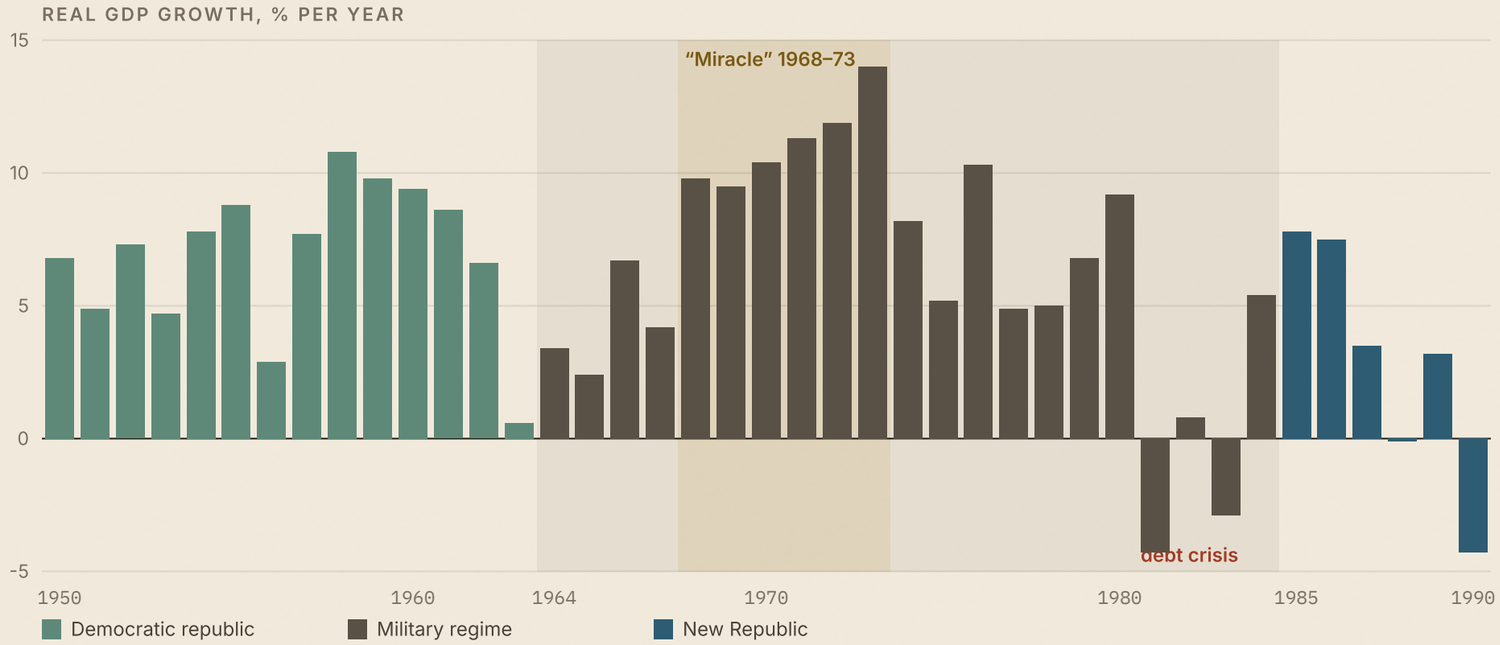
Brasília and the new trunk roads (schematic)

What it did to Rio

Rio became the city-state of Guanabara (1960–75), then was merged into Rio de Janeiro state. It lost federal jobs, political centrality and fiscal autonomy — the beginning of a long relative decline that shapes the city you will see.

Left: aerial survey of Brasília, June 1958 (Arquivo Nacional). Holston (1989); CPDOC.

The generals' bargain: rapid growth without democracy — and with rising inequality

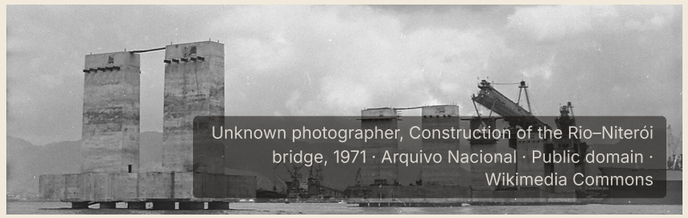


On 31 March–1 April 1964 the army deposed the elected president João Goulart, with support from much of the middle class, business, the press and the Church hierarchy — and a US naval task force on standby. The generals ruled for 21 years, keeping a tame Congress and rotating presidents.

After the **AI-5** decree of December 1968 came censorship and systematic torture; the National Truth Commission (2014) documented **434** people killed or disappeared by the state.

The "miracle" averaged over 10% growth in 1968–73, on wage restraint, state investment and foreign credit. When oil prices quadrupled in 1973 the regime kept growing on borrowed money; foreign debt passed $100 billion and the 1980s became a lost decade.

Unknown photographer, Troops in Rio during the coup, 2 April 1964 · Arquivo Nacional / Correio da Manhã · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

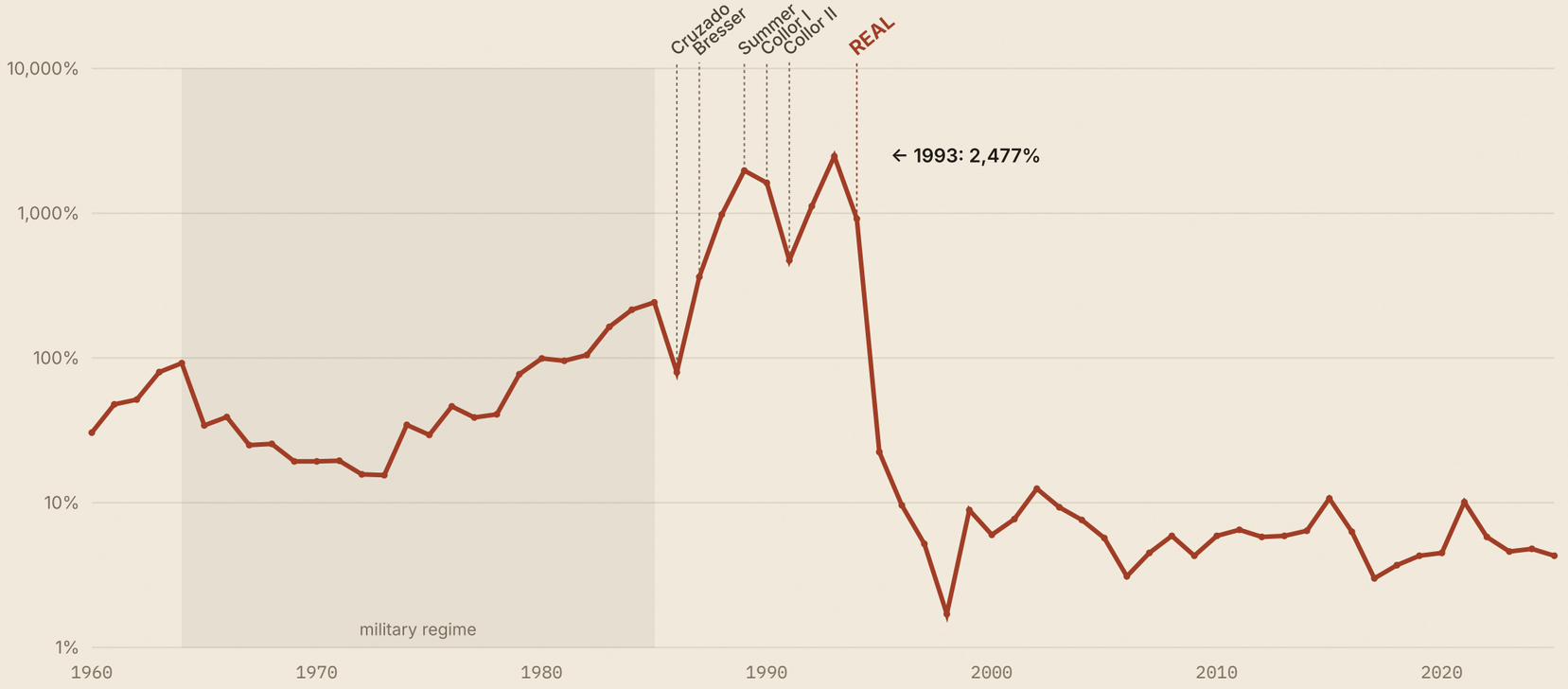


Unknown photographer, Construction of the Rio–Niterói bridge, 1971 · Arquivo Nacional · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

GDP: IBGE / Ipeadata (real growth). Left: troops in Rio, 2 April 1964; right: building the Rio–Niterói bridge (1971), a miracle-era megaproject. CNV (2014); Gaspari; Fishlow (1972).

Inflation became a way of life — until an ingenious plan broke it in 1994

CONSUMER PRICE INFLATION, % PER YEAR — LOGARITHMIC SCALE · FAILED STABILISATION PLANS MARKED



HOW THE REAL PLAN WORKED

1. Indexation had become the disease

Wages, rents and contracts were all corrected for past inflation, so inflation reproduced itself ("inertial inflation"). Price freezes failed five times.

2. A virtual currency first

From March 1994 every price was quoted in the URV — a unit of account worth about one dollar — while people still paid in cruzeiros reais. Prices realigned voluntarily, without a freeze.

3. Then the switch

On 1 July 1994 the URV became the real (R$1 = CR$2,750). Inflation fell from about 2,500% to 22% in a year, then single digits.

Five currencies in eight years: cruzado (1986), cruzado novo (1989), cruzeiro (1990), cruzeiro real (1993), real (1994).

IBGE IPCA (1980–2025); FGV IGP-DI (1960–79). Arida & Lara Resende (1985); Franco (1995).

Democracy returned by negotiation — with a constitution that promised more than the state could pay for

Jorge Henrique Singh, Diretas Já rally, 1984 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Diretas Já, 1984: rallies of up to a million people — including at Candelária in Rio — demanded direct presidential elections. Congress voted the amendment down.

1974	Geisel announces a “slow, gradual and secure” opening
1979	Amnesty — for exiles and for torturers
1985	Civilian president chosen indirectly
1988	New constitution (5 October)
1989	First direct presidential vote since 1960

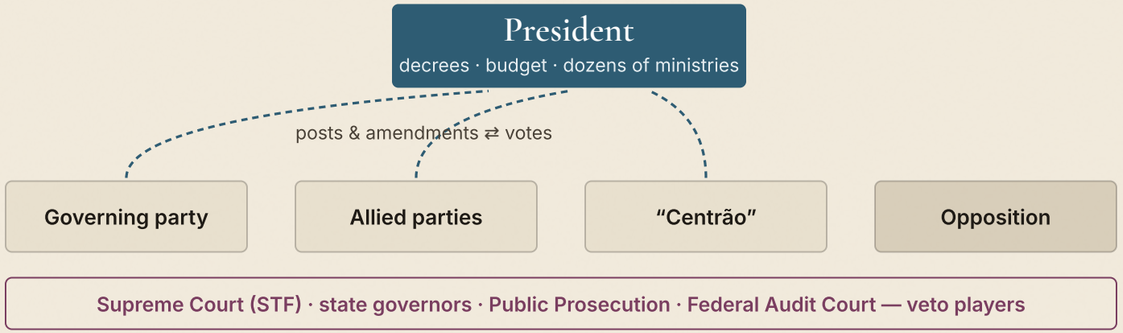
What 1988 created

A universal public health system (SUS); pensions and social assistance as rights; votes from 16 and for the illiterate; Indigenous and quilombola land rights; an independent public prosecution service; strong judicial review.

How the system works

A powerful president who governs through decrees and coalitions; a Congress fragmented among a dozen-plus parties, with a pragmatic “Centrão” that trades votes for posts and budget amendments; a Supreme Court that often arbitrates politics.

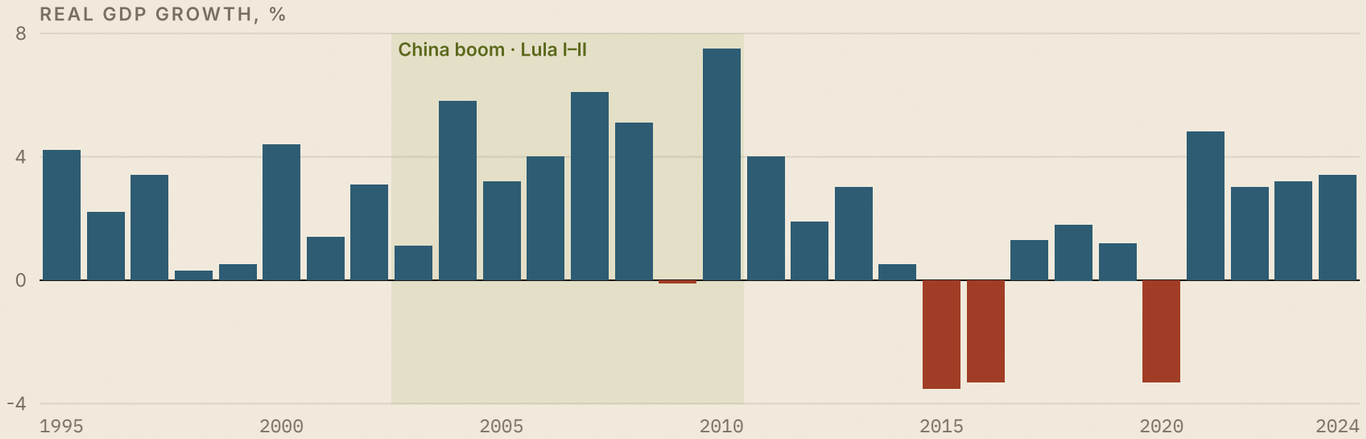
COALITIONAL PRESIDENTIALISM (SCHEMATIC)

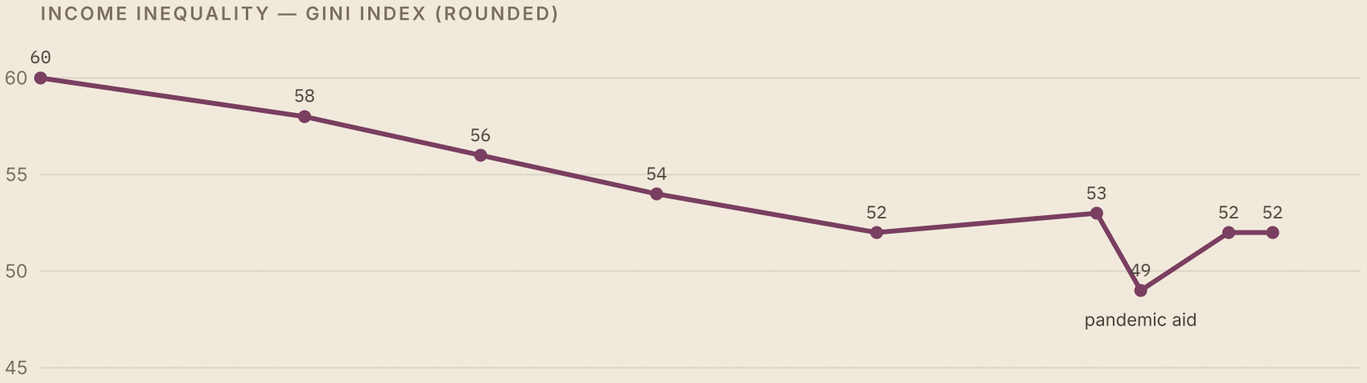


Since 1988: two presidents impeached (Collor 1992, Rousseff 2016) and more than 130 constitutional amendments.

Abranches (1988, 2018); Fausto & Fausto (2014); Constitution of 1988.

A commodity boom, real social gains — then a decade of crisis and polarisation





Stable money (FHC, 1995–2002) and then Chinese demand for iron ore, soy and oil financed the **Lula** years (2003–10): real minimum-wage gains, the Bolsa Família cash-transfer programme, credit, and a historic fall in poverty and inequality.

From 2013: mass street protests, the **Lava Jato** corruption probe, the worst recession on record (2015–16), the impeachment of Dilma Rousseff (2016) and the election of the far-right Jair Bolsonaro (2018). After a riot stormed Congress, the presidential palace and the Supreme Court on 8 January 2023, the Court convicted Bolsonaro in 2025 of plotting a coup.

AS OF 24 OCTOBER 2026

Election: first round (4 Oct) — Flávio Bolsonaro 47.0%, President Lula 45.2%; the runoff is on **25 October**, result not known at writing. Jair Bolsonaro is serving a 27-year sentence under house arrest.

Economy: policy rate (Selic) 13.75% after September's cut; inflation expected near 5% for 2026; growth forecasts below 2%.

GDP: IBGE / Ipeadata through 2024. Gini: World Bank PIP / IBGE PNAD, rounded. Election: TSE count via Al Jazeera & Washington Post (Oct 2026); Selic: BCB Copom (Sept 2026); STF AP 2668. Contemporary figures provisional.

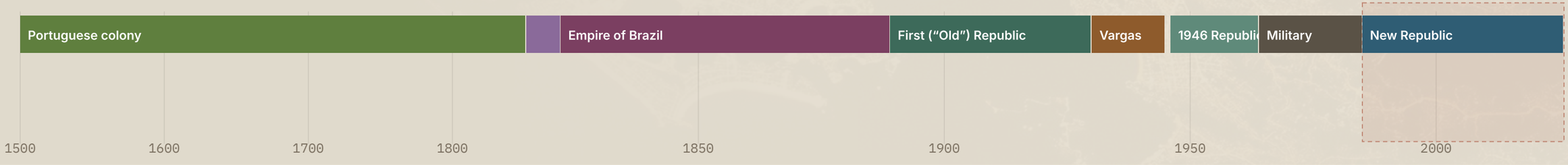
NASA, Rio de Janeiro at night from the International Space Stat..., 2022 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Act V

Reading Brazil and Rio Today

the present, through the past

Now that you know the history, what do the regions, the inequalities and the shape of Rio itself tell you?



Five regions, five histories — each the residue of a different cycle

REGION	POP.	GDP	WHERE IT COMES FROM
North Manaus · Belém	8.5%	≈6%	Amazon frontier: missions, rubber boom (1879–1912), Manaus Free Trade Zone (1967), today's deforestation frontier and largest Indigenous territories.
Northeast Salvador · Recife · Fortaleza	26.9%	≈14%	The original sugar colony and Afro-Brazilian heartland; drought-prone sertão; for a century the great source of migrants to Rio and São Paulo. Lula's electoral base.
Southeast São Paulo · Rio · Belo Horizonte	41.8%	≈52%	Gold, coffee, industry and finance in succession. Holds both mega-cities, most of the country's capital — and its largest urban peripheries.
South Porto Alegre · Curitiba	14.7%	≈17%	Gaúcho cattle frontier facing the River Plate, then German and Italian smallholder colonies and cooperatives. Highest human-development scores.
Centre-West Brasília · Goiânia · Cuiabá	8%	≈11%	Brasília, and since the 1970s the Cerrado agribusiness frontier — soy, corn, cotton, cattle — made possible by soil science. Fastest-growing region.

Three capitals of three kinds: Brasília governs, São Paulo produces and finances, Rio represents — the country's showcase, oil-and-gas hub, media centre and the city through which most foreigners first meet Brazil. Salvador, the first capital (1549–1763), remains its Afro-Brazilian cultural capital.

Population: IBGE Censo 2022. GDP shares: IBGE Contas Regionais (c. 2021), rounded.

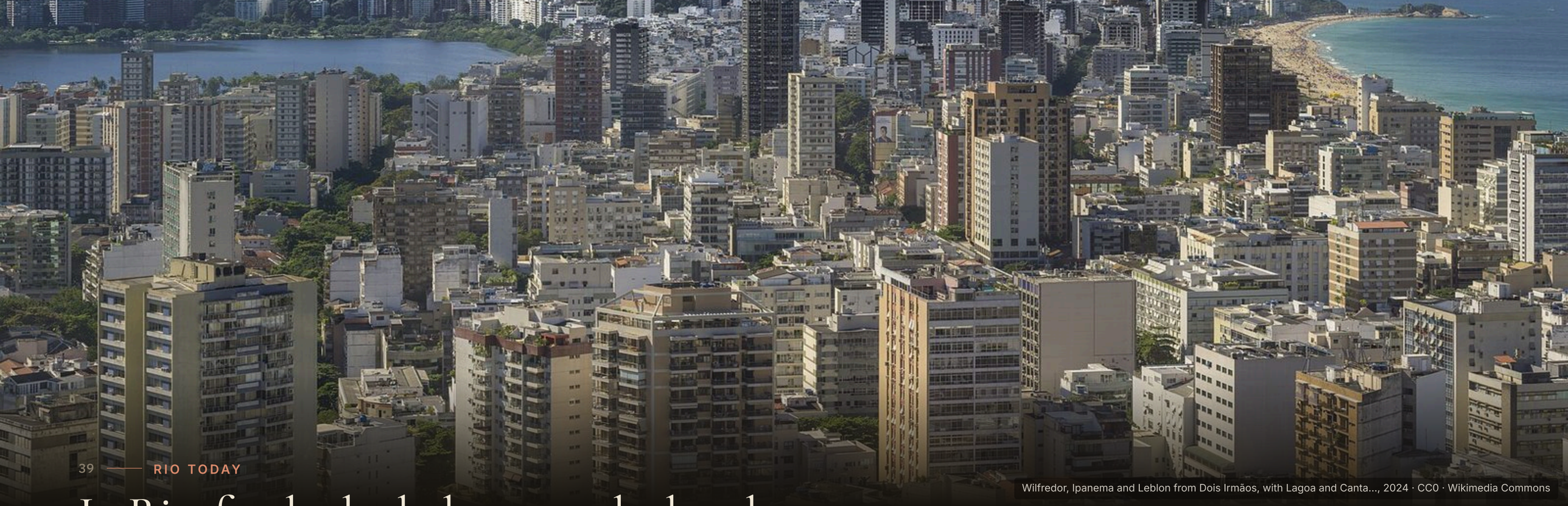
Why inequality endures: five layers laid down over five centuries

LAID DOWN	LAYER	MECHANISM	WHAT YOU CAN STILL MEASURE
1530s–1850	Land	Royal land grants to the few; then the 1850 Land Law made land purchasable only for cash, just as the slave trade ended.	Land ownership remains among the most concentrated on earth (land Gini ≈ 0.86).
1550–1888	Slavery without reconstruction	Four centuries of slavery; abolition with no land, schooling or compensation; subsidised European immigrants preferred for the new jobs.	Black and pardo Brazilians earn roughly 40% less than white Brazilians.
1930s–	A dual labour state	Vargas protected urban formal workers; rural and domestic workers were excluded for decades.	About 4 in 10 workers are informal, outside the protections of the CLT.
1964–1994	Inflation & indexation	Indexed accounts shielded the banked middle and upper classes; cash-holding poor paid the inflation tax.	A legacy of very high real interest rates that reward holders of public debt.
1988–	Fiscal design	Taxes lean on consumption; dividends were untaxed from 1996; generous public pensions; free public universities long dominated by the privately schooled.	The top 1% receive roughly a quarter of national income (tax data).

But inequality is not fate. Between 2001 and 2014 the Gini index fell by about six points — through a rising minimum wage, mass schooling, pensions and cash transfers — before stalling. A 2025 income-tax law, in force from 2026, exempts low earners and imposes a minimum tax on very high incomes, including dividends.

Read the layers as **sediment**: each era added a mechanism without removing the earlier ones. That is why Brazil can be a high-tech agricultural power with world-class banks and, at the same time, a country where millions live without sewerage.

IBGE Censo Agropecuário 2017 (land Gini); PNAD Contínua (informality, income by colour); Souza (2018) on top incomes; Arretche (ed., 2015).



Wilfredor, Ipanema and Leblon from Dois Irmãos, with Lagoa and Canta..., 2024 · CC0 · Wikimedia Commons

In Rio, favelas look down on the beach — and the true periphery is out of sight

Hills beside the jobs

Steep, often publicly owned slopes were left out of the formal market; workers built there, a walk from the households, hotels and building sites of the Zona Sul. Rocinha — 72,021 people in 2022 — sits between Gávea and São Conrado.

The periphery you won't see

Most poor cariocas live far from the beaches — in the North and West Zones and the Baixada Fluminense, with commutes of two hours or more. About 15% of greater Rio lives in favelas (2022 census).

Policy swings

Removals in the 1960s–70s (to Cidade de Deus and Vila Kennedy); upgrading from the 1990s; armed "pacification" from 2008; today drug factions and militias contest territory. A police raid in Penha and Alemão on 28 October 2025 killed more than 120 people — the deadliest in the city's history.

Top: Ipanema and Leblon from Dois Irmãos, with Lagoa and the Cantagalo hill (Wilfredor, 2024, CC0). IBGE Censo 2022; Perlman (2010); Valladares (2005); Rio Public Defender's Office (2025).

Twenty-four places where Rio's history is still visible

Hover or click a number.

1 COURT & EMPIRE (1808–1889)

Praça XV & Paço Imperial

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

A plain colonial palace on a square by the ferry docks; the Arco do Teles alley beside it.

WHAT IT MEANS

The governors' house (1743) became the royal palace in 1808. João VI was acclaimed here (1818); Princess Isabel signed the Golden Law here (1888). Brazil's political centre for two centuries.

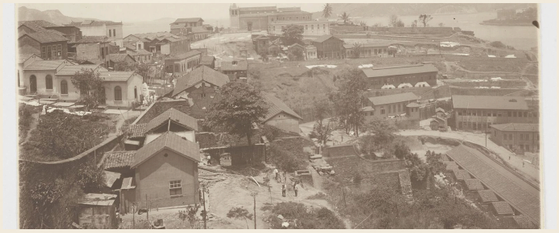
Slides 15, 20

LAYERS

- Colonial (1565–1808)
- Gold & slave port (1700–1850)
- Court & Empire (1808–1889)
- Republic & Belle Époque (1889–1945)
- Modern Rio (1945–today)

Positions approximate. Relief: AWS Terrain Tiles; coastline IBGE.

Eight things you will now notice in Rio — and what they mean



Flat ground where hills used to be

The Esplanada do Castelo and the area around Largo da Carioca are the sites of demolished hills — including the one the city was founded on.

A shoreline that is mostly man-made

The Aterro, Santos Dumont airport and the port all stand on landfill — much of it made from those hills. Glória church once stood by the water.

A palace that is just a big house

The Paço is modest because it was a colonial governor's residence improvised into the seat of an empire.

Africa underfoot in the port

In Saúde and Gamboa the Valongo stones, the Pretos Novos cemetery and Pedra do Sal mark the largest slave port in the Americas.

Gustavo Capanema Palace (Ministry of Education and Health)

Three cities on one walk

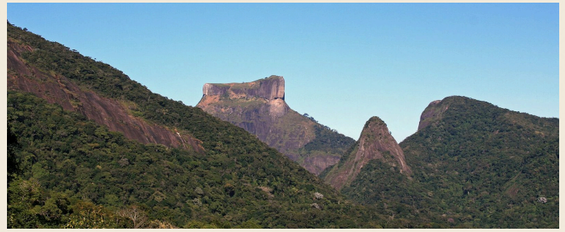
Colonial churches, Passos's Parisian façades and Vargas-era modernism (the Capanema Palace) stand within a few blocks — each era rebuilt the centre in its own image.

The mountain is a class line

Zona Sul faces the ocean; the Zona Norte lies behind the massif along the railway. Tunnels, not distance, separate them. Favelas climb the slopes in between.

The beach is the public square

Since the 1920s the beach replaced the bay as Rio's stage — the one space everyone shares, subdivided by posto, tribe and neighbourhood.



The rainforest is a 19th-century garden

Coffee stripped the Tijuca hills; from 1861 the Empire replanted them to save the water supply — one of the first large reforestations anywhere.

Photographs: Augusto Malta (Morro do Castelo, 1921); Pppires; Fulviusbsas; Ian Storni Machado; Henrique Liberal; Chensiyuan; Mteixeira62; Halley Pacheco de Oliveira — via Wikimedia Commons (see credits).

Eight mental models to carry with you

1 Brazil is a South Atlantic creation

It was built as much from Angola and the Bight of Benin as from Portugal. Its people, music, religion and food — and its wealth — came across that ocean.

2 Export cycles move the centre of gravity

Brazilwood, sugar, gold, coffee, industry, soy and oil each created a new core and left an old one behind, with its elites and inequalities intact.

3 Slavery was the operating system

Not one sector but the organising principle of society for 350 years — and abolition came without land, schooling or rights. Its hierarchy outlived it.

4 Change by accommodation

Independence by a prince, a republic by coup, amnesty for both sides, democracy by indirect election. Regimes change; elites negotiate; structures persist.

5 A strong state for insiders

From the Vargas labour code to pensions and public universities, the state protects those inside the formal system — and leaves a vast informal Brazil outside.

6 Booms on borrowed time

Growth spurts have depended on external prices or credit — coffee, foreign loans, China — and ended in busts, inflation or debt. Hence the cycles of promise and disappointment.

7 Rio was the national stage

Capital for two centuries, it was where Brazil performed itself — court, abolition, samba, carnival, football, bossa nova. Since 1960 it has been a stage without the state.

8 In Rio, geography is class

Mountain and sea, tunnels and railways, hills removed and shores filled: read the terrain and you can read the social order.

Marc Ferrez, Panorama of Rio de Janeiro, 1889 · Instituto Moreira Salles · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

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Scroll within this panel. Every slide's own sources are listed in its deeper-explanation drawer (N).

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